



Why Publishers Still Use Plain Text Public Contributor Credits Despite YouTube @Mentions - PM Case Study (Prajesh Dave)

★ Executive summary

YouTube supports @mentions for tagging contributors, yet most publishers continue to use plain-text credits in descriptions.

This case study explores why an existing feature with clear benefits remains underutilized, identifies root causes across workflow, incentives, and UX friction, and proposes solutions to increase adoption of structured contributor tagging.

Outcome I'm optimizing for

A higher adoption of contributor tagging by publishers, leading to improved discoverability for contributors, better metadata quality for YouTube, and a richer viewer ecosystem experience.

Product Hypothesis

▶ Contributor credits are an under-leveraged metadata layer on YouTube.

If we structure credits and connect them to identity,

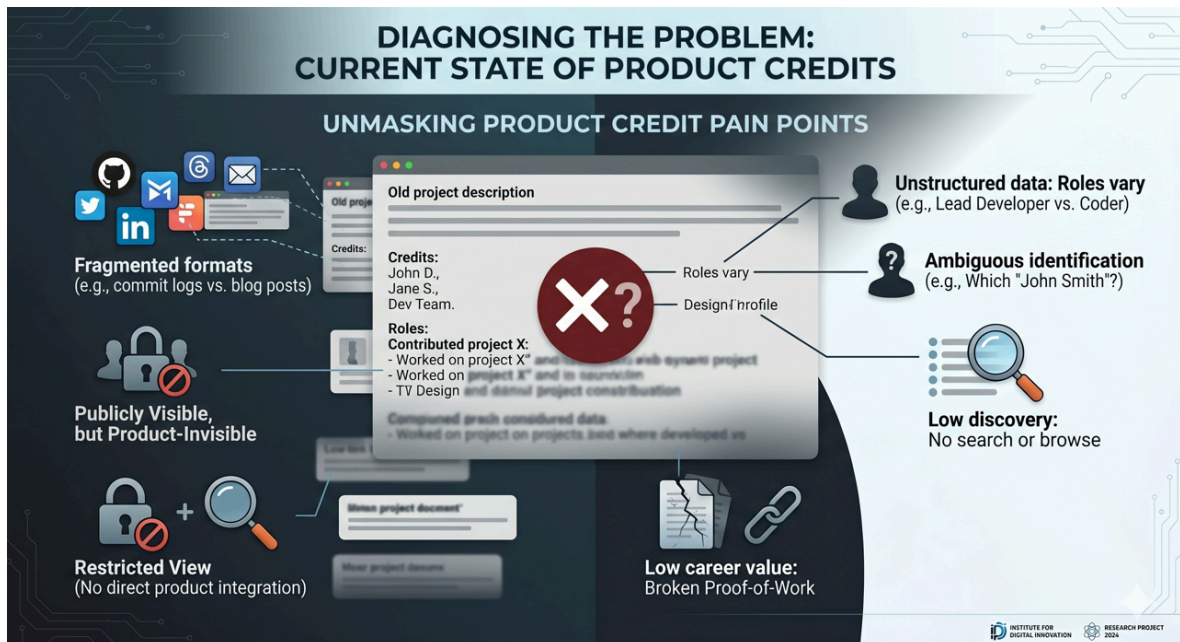
then we unlock talent discovery, improve search relevance, and increase creator ecosystem stickiness.



Problem statement

Despite the availability of @mentions, publishers frequently rely on plain text for contributor credits.

What's Broken Today

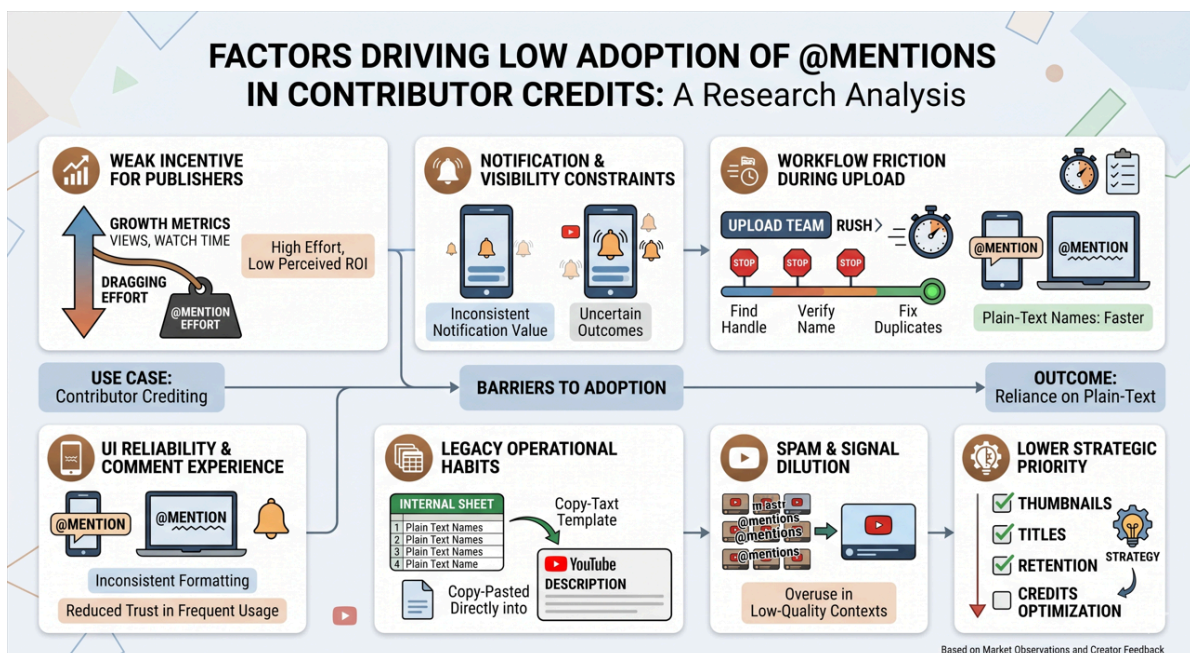


Current state example

Song XYZ Official Video
Singer: Rahul
Lyrics: by Neha
Guitar: Rutvij Joshi
Mixing: Studio Team
Directed by Priya Shah

Why Existing @Mentions See Low Adoption in Contributor Credits

Although YouTube supports @mentions, real-world adoption for contributor crediting appears limited. Based on market observations, creator feedback, and platform behavior, several barriers may explain continued reliance on plain-text credits.



Core Product Insight

The challenge may not be missing functionality, but insufficient motivation, friction-heavy workflows, and unclear value realization.

What This Means for My Case Study

The right opportunity is not "build mentions," but:

- reduce tagging friction
- improve discoverability value
- create better incentives
- streamline credit workflows

Existing Capability vs Real Usage

Capability	Reality
@mentions supported	rarely used in credits
clickable identities	mostly plain text
contributor tagging possible	inconsistent adoption

Why this matters (and to whom)



Contributors

Not tagged →
Lose visibility



Viewers

Cannot explore
contributors easily



Uploaders / Publishers

Tagging increases
effort without
clear reward

Why This Matters to YouTube

Business Impact

- richer metadata graph
- stronger creator retention
- contributor ecosystem growth
- improved search relevance
- cross-channel discovery

User research / observations

I approached this as a metadata + ecosystem product: the behavior already exists (people credit), the product doesn't yet capture it.

What I observe in the wild

- Credits appear across music videos, podcasts, documentaries, short films, and branded content.
- The longer the project, the longer the description, credits become "scroll tax."
- Common names create confusion (multiple "Rahul"s) and reduce the incentive to credit.
- Credits are often copied/pasted across videos, causing spelling drift.

Jobs-to-be-done

- **Uploader:** "Help me credit collaborators correctly with minimal effort."
- **Contributor:** "Let me prove my work history and be discoverable for the next job."

- **Viewer:** “Let me explore creators behind the content I love.”

Key insights

- 🔑 1) The supply of credits already exists, **the missing layer is structure + identity**.
- 2) If we make credits useful (portfolio + discovery), we create a **positive loop**: more credits → better graph → better discovery → more incentives to credit.

Current Experience Gaps (Gap Analysis)

Moment	What happens today	Why it's a problem
During upload	Creator manually types credits	High variance + errors; discourages completeness
Watching	Viewer expands description, scans text	Low visibility; almost no exploration
Discovery	Search can't reliably index contributors	Lost intent (“show me videos directed by X”)
Career value	Contributor screenshots descriptions	Weak, non-verifiable proof-of-work

Opportunity size (what I'd quantify)

- 🔧 Improve adoption of existing contributor tagging features to unlock discoverability, metadata quality, and creator ecosystem value.

Lever	Proxy metric (how I'd measure)	Why it matters
Eligible inventory	% of uploads with “credit-like” patterns in description	Upper bound on adoption
Graph growth	# unique contributors + roles captured / day	Powers discovery + search relevance
Engagement	Credits module opens + profile clicks	Validates user value
Ecosystem value	Contributor claim rate + returning publishers	Long-term defensibility

Proposed solution: Public Credits 2.0

Solutions to Increase Adoption:

- **Smart Mention Suggestions** (When typing names → suggest matching accounts)
- **Structured Credits Input During Upload** (Role + name → auto-tagging)
- **One-Click Conversion** (Convert plain text credits into tagged format)
- **Incentive Layer** (Show benefits: profile clicks, engagement, discoverability)
- **Dedicated Credits UI** (Make credits visible, not buried)

Feature concepts (V1 → V2)

1) Credits module (on watch page)

A dedicated "Credits" section below the video, collapsed by default with an "Expand" affordance.

2) Structured upload flow

Add contributors with Role + Name, powered by autocomplete + recent collaborators.

3) Clickable profiles (claim + verify)

Link to a contributor profile (or allow claiming later). Support disambiguation.

4) Search & discovery

Enable queries like: "Videos directed by Priya Shah", "Songs featuring Rutvij Joshi".

5) Portfolio export (later)

A contributor-facing portfolio view: credited projects, roles, and featured work.

Visual mockups (placeholders)

These are intentionally lightweight to keep the focus on product logic; in a real loop I'd pair with high-fidelity mocks.



Watch page: Credits module

[Mockup placeholder]

- Credits (collapsed) → expands to top contributors
- "Show all" opens full list

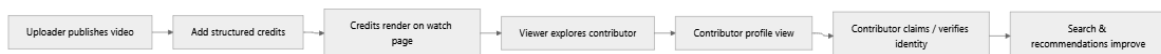


Upload: Add contributors

[Mockup placeholder]

- Role dropdown + name field
- Autocomplete from past collaborators

User journey (end-to-end)



Uploader

- Add contributors during upload (or import from template)
- System suggests frequent collaborators

Contributor

- Get notified when credited (optional)
- Claim profile, consolidate credits, feature top work

Viewer

- Tap Credits → open contributor → follow / watch more

Metrics / KPIs (dashboard-style)

Feature	Why
smart suggestions	reduces friction
structured input	standardizes flow
conversion tool	leverages existing behavior

Prioritization framework (RICE)

Feature	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort	Priority
Credits module (watch page)	High	High	Medium	Medium	P1
Structured upload form	High	High	Medium	Medium	P1
Clickable profiles (claiming)	Medium	High	Medium	Medium	P1
Search by contributor	Medium	Medium	Low	High	P2
Portfolio export	Low	High	Low	Medium	P3

Risks & tradeoffs



Risk: Upload friction

Mitigation: quick-add mode, templates, and post-publish edits.



Risk: Credits clutter

Mitigation: show “top contributors” by default + expand to full list; allow role grouping.



Risk: Incorrect spellings / impersonation

Mitigation: autocomplete, unique IDs, claiming flows, and verified badges (for high-signal contributors).

Rollout roadmap

Phase	Who	What ships	Success criteria
Phase 1	Music labels + verified creators	Credits module + upload form + basic profiles	Adoption on high-volume channels; low upload drop-off
Phase 2	Podcasts + production-heavy channels	Role taxonomy expansion + claiming improvements	Higher credits completeness; increasing profile CTR
Phase 3	All creators	Scale + search integration	Sustained north star growth across upload types

Final recommendation

- ★ By reducing friction, improving visibility, and aligning incentives, YouTube can significantly improve how contributor credits are used and valued.

What This Project Demonstrated

- Identified a feature **adoption gap** rather than a feature gap, a key product management insight.
- Many product problems are not about missing features, but about unused ones.

Product Sense

Recognized an existing user behavior (public credits) and identified an underutilized product opportunity.

User Empathy

Balanced needs of uploaders, contributors, and viewers.

Analytical Thinking

Translated qualitative pain points into measurable KPIs and adoption metrics.

Prioritization

Sequenced MVP features to maximize impact while minimizing friction.

Business Acumen

Linked contributor credits to search quality, engagement, and ecosystem growth.

Communication

Structured a clear narrative from problem discovery to solution roadmap.